PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Land Rover Discovery Series II

1998–2004 · L318 · Td5 · 4.0 / 4.6 V8 · ACE

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rear chassis and crossmember**
  The back of the frame, around the fuel tank and the rear crossmember, rots from the inside out where mud and water collect. Look closely at the rear chassis legs, the crossmember and the suspension hangers, because owners report hangers collapsing. Replacement rear quarter and half chassis sections exist, and so do whole galvanised frames, which tells you how common this is.

- [ ] **Sills, arches, boot floor and body mounts**
  One LandyZone member's under-seal inspection turned up rotten footwells, inner and outer sills, all four arches, the boot floor and both rear body mounts, with a £5,040 repair quote. Expect to find at least twice the rust you can see once you start cutting.

- [ ] **Td5 head, fuel in the oil**
  Famous Four says Td5 cylinder-head failure is now quite common and expensive. Check the dipstick: a level that is too high suggests diesel in the oil. Failed injector sealing washers cause the same symptom and are much cheaper to fix, so diagnose before you condemn the head.

- [ ] **Oil in the ECU plug**
  Lift the ECU out of its tray by the battery and look at the connectors. Oil there means the injector harness seals under the rocker cover have failed, and in time that causes misfires and poor starting. The fix is a cheap harness, but neglected trucks may also have oil in the main engine loom.

- [ ] **Diesel leak at the back of the Td5**
  Diesel weeping from the rear of the cylinder head on the driver's side is usually the fuel pressure regulator. Fix it quickly: Famous Four warns that leaking fuel can drip onto the starter motor and kill it.

- [ ] **V8 cooling and head gaskets**
  Ask for head-gasket and cooling records. An Expedition Portal buyer's guide says gaskets often go between 50,000 and 70,000 miles and advises avoiding trucks with a compromised cooling system. Owners also report slipped or cracked cylinder liners, especially on 2003–04 4.6s, which mean an engine rebuild with top-hat liners or a replacement block.

- [ ] **SLS, ACE and the 'three amigos'**
  A tail that sags overnight means leaking SLS air springs. Oil on the chassis rails or around the anti-roll bars means ACE leaks, which Famous Four calls 'very expensive to rectify'. ABS, TC and HDC lights together (the 'three amigos') are often a dirty or failed wheel sensor, but can be a failing ABS modulator costing thousands.

- [ ] **Centre diff lock and propshafts**
  Pre-facelift trucks have the lock in the transfer box but often no lever, unless someone has fitted one. On the test drive, a severe shimmy points to worn propshaft joints; the front shaft's double-cardan joint has non-greasable UJs from the factory, and the rear rubber coupling cracks.

YEARS TO KNOW

1998–2000	BEWARE	Early Td5 oil-pump drive and head-stud ('head shuffle') problems, fixed within two years; ACE pipe and idler-pulley recalls
2003–04	BEWARE	US owners report slipped and cracked liners on late 4.0 and especially 4.6 blocks

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **ACE high-pressure pipe can fracture at the pump**
  1999–2000 · NHTSA 00V036000 / 00V423000
- ☐ **Left-side engine idler pulley can fracture**
  1999–2000 · NHTSA 00V142000 / 00V142001
- ☐ **Water in automatic transmission fluid; park lock**
  1999–2001 · NHTSA 00V377000
- ☐ **ABS sensor contamination causes unwanted ABS activation**
  1999–2001 · NHTSA 02V022000
- ☐ **Accelerator cable kinked at assembly**
  1999–2002 · NHTSA 02V028000
- ☐ **Throttle can stick intermittently**
  2003 · NHTSA 03V133000
- ☐ **ABS modulator valve-cover bolts can crack**
  1999–2004 · NHTSA 04V005000
- ☐ **ACE pump banjo bolt loses torque**
  2000–2003 · NHTSA 04V006000
- ☐ **Replacement rear driveshaft coupling (service part)**
  1999–2004 · NHTSA 12E010000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Series I or Series II?**
  The Series II's rear stop lights sit above the window line (the Series I's are below), the paddle door handles are gone, the tail is longer, and the wheels are 5×120 instead of the Series I's 5×6.5 in.
- ☐ **Pre-facelift or facelift (D2a)?**
  Facelift trucks (2003 model year on) have 'pocketed' headlamps like the L322 Range Rover and revised rear lamps with the indicators moved up out of the bumper.
- ☐ **Td5 10P or 15P**
  Later Euro 3 Td5s (15P) have EGR and a fuel pressure regulator with an extra return pipe. Order Td5 parts by chassis number because many changed mid-run.
- ☐ **SLS and ACE**
  SLS trucks have rear air springs instead of coils and a compressor in a plastic box on the left-hand chassis rail, level with the front seats. ACE trucks have a valve block on the right-hand chassis rail with steel lines running to the anti-roll bars.
- ☐ **Centre diff lock**
  Look for a diff-lock position on the transfer lever. Early trucks have the lock in the LT230 but no linkage unless one has been fitted from a Discovery 1 (matching manual or auto) or a kit.
- ☐ **US truck or import**
  US-market Series IIs were all V8 automatics (4.0 for 1999–2002, 4.6 for 2003–04). A Td5 or manual in the US is a private import, so check the VIN, build date and paperwork.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-rover/discovery-2/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks